

The Routine

It is essential that all trumpet players develop a warmup and fundamentals routine that works for them and their specific needs. This is to develop and preserve our trumpet technique. Mastery of this technique is the key to being able achieve musical expression. There are many different systems and pedagogical approaches to accomplish this daily task. For efficiency, (there are only so many hours in a day, and so many notes we can play per hour) I like to organize this daily task into 5 “buckets,” into which you can put different aspects of playing that need to be addressed every day. This modular approach allows you to swap out different specific exercises and methods depending on your current playing challenges. There is some overlap between the buckets, but we will go over the details of specific materials for each in warmup class:

1. Preparing to Play

- Stretches/Centering
- Breathing
- Buzzing

2. Long tones/Flow Studies– development and maintenance of a resonant, ringing tone quality with good intonation, evenness and ease across the registers. Also, development of a smooth and relaxed airstream to support our sound. This section progresses from slow to fast moving slurred materials, culminating in “flow etudes” from the famed Cichowicz collection.

TIPS: Always take a full, relaxed breath. Be wary of adding resistance to the air at either the lips or the throat. Concentrate on “leading” with the air (i.e. the air initiates lip vibration, the release of the air - shaped by the tongue – creates articulation, etc.) Think of releasing a focused and energized air column into the instrument. Quality breathing fosters a healthy, resilient embouchure, although you do not need to blow or “move” a lot of air like a tuba player. The hole of our trumpet mouthpiece is small, and it will back up on you quickly. Blow only enough to create a standing wave of resonance that the instrument will amplify into a beautiful sound. This is the balance that creates efficient trumpet playing but takes some time to discover.

- ### 3. Articulation Studies – development and maintenance of a variety of articulations, (long/short, fast/slow, loud/soft, high/low and their combinations) and specific stylistic application (marcato may look the same but sound vastly different in Beethoven, Mahler, Stravinsky, or Ellington). Developing a relaxed but clear and fast single tongue in all registers, dynamics and intervals is essential. TIPS: These studies improve accuracy and consistency especially when we maintain the focus on sound, not the distractions of feel, muscle activity and placement. Attack with a full sound but not at the expense of agility.
- ### 4. Flexibility Studies – development and maintenance of the ability to move quickly and easily between notes, especially across wide leaps and chord tones, in a smooth and nimble manner. TIPS: slow practice here is helpful but don’t forget to expand your comfort zone into fast slurring. Listen for a smooth, resonant transfer of sound from one note to the next. Remember,

while you can't always control the lips, you can control the musical message you send to them. Your imagination is powerful. If you can hear it, you can (eventually) play it.

5. **Mental Studies** - training aspects of trumpet playing that rely more on the mind and ear than the physical coordination of the body (lips, tongue, wind etc.)
 - Sight-reading
 - Transposition
 - Odd Meter & Contemporary patterns/techniques

Expectations

Etiquette & Professionalism: You are part of the fellowship of trumpet players. This lineage includes all students and professionals currently making music with the trumpet, as well as the players that came before us. It is expected that we take pride in this fellowship and represent ourselves and the Trumpet Studio well. Work to impress your classroom teachers, ensemble conductors and peers with your level of preparation and respectful, professional behavior. Be a leader and set an example for those around you, especially in the following areas:

- Always be early (on time is already late)
- Be willing to accept constructive criticism and try new things.
- Be kind and supportive to your colleagues. Music is a collaborative endeavor. Be someone people like working with and being around.
- Practice good ensemble skills – blending, tuning, matching note lengths & articulations etc. Everyone benefits when you do your best to make your colleagues sound their best.
- Beware that your posture and body language can give away what you are thinking and betray your best intentions.
- Always have extra pencils with you and write in all changes in your music. You will forget if you don't write it in and you will be giving sabotaging your ability to sound your best.
- Clean and maintain your instrument so it functions properly. If you miss a note because the valve sticks, the audience (and likely most of your colleagues) only know that you missed a note. They can't see your sticky valve, and don't care about it.
- Always bring all of your music.
- Always bring your mutes, or even an extra one! Different mutes will sound better for certain passages and you look professional when you can offer a different timbre to the conductor simply with a different mute. These small things show you care about the music and are reliable. It also gives you an extra mute, in case your section mate forgets. Everyone having a mute makes the section look and sound better.
- Don't talk or use your phone during rehearsals.
- Count all the rests, ALL THE TIME. This is as important as playing the right notes. It shows you care, you respect the music and your fellow musicians, and you are reliable.
- We all have egos, especially as artists. Try your best to put your ego aside and make musical decisions that will serve and respect the music. This guiding principle will steer you towards

integrity in your musical interpretations, and build wide-ranging, long-lasting respect of your colleagues and teachers.

Collegiality: Each year brings new musicians into the studio and we strive to create a supportive, inclusive learning environment. Studio camaraderie is created through listening and learning from each other as we all contend with similar trumpet playing challenges.

General Preparation: Practice everyday and be prepared always. If you skip one day, you notice. If you skip 2 days, your colleagues and conductors notice. If you skip 3 days, the audience notices. Consistent and regular practice is critical to achieving growth as a musician and trumpeter. You will be expected to devote ample time to the development of your instrumental technique, musicianship, and to the realization of performance goals as discussed in your lessons. The fine motor movements and coordination required to perform a musical instrument at a high level require dedicated repetition, a curiosity for the exploration of new skills, and the desire to translate your inner voice into music others can hear; to say something with your horn. While we are together a few hours per week with lessons, studio and warmup classes, it is up to you to translate what we speak about there, into meaningful improvements in the practice room. It is my job to teach you how to teach yourself.

Lesson Preparation

A primary goal of collegiate applied music lessons is to find your distinct musical voice. This happens through thoughtful listening of world-class performances and imitating what they do until it is your own. We work on technique to allow us to sing our song and this allows us to connect with the listener. This is the most important work we can do together, but we can only operate at this level if you learn the nuts and bolts of your assigned music (notes, rhythms, fingerings, tempi, basic articulation etc.) before the lesson, then allowing us to focus on more rewarding aspects of music making (phrasing, musical style, musical context, subtle variances in articulation, tone color, note shape etc.)

Recording devices and Microphones

One of the quickest ways to improve is self-recording. You can do this on your existing computer, tablet or smartphone but will get much more out of the experience if you can invest in an external microphone or dedicated recording device that takes high quality (16bit, 44.1khz, WAV format) audio recordings. While helpful good for personal study, this is also important to make audition recordings for music festivals, graduate schools and professional jobs.

Studio Class, Warm-up/Technique class, Trumpet Ensemble

Studio classes is required each week and will consist of occasional lectures on a topic of trumpet pedagogy, large trumpet choir, and student performances. Each week, different members of the studio will perform something from their studies, so that every student performs something for their peers every few weeks. This performance does not have to be completely polished but rather is a workshop

environment to help hone our musical decisions, technical challenges and performance anxieties in real time in front of our supportive and encouraging peers. Performing in an informal setting is an excellent way to focus your practice and prepare for more formal appearances, while cultivating a positive performing environment across the studio.